



A Messy Table, A Map of the World: Heda's Still Life

Introduction

A Messy Table, A Map of the World: Heda's Still Life

Focus work

Willem Claesz Heda, *Still Life with a Gilt Cup*, 1635, Rijksmuseum, Amsterdam

Goal for today

Use close looking to show how a Dutch breakfast table can map trade, class, and value. Write one clear paragraph that makes a claim using visual and historical evidence.

What you will do

1. Look and label

- On your print, label every object you see.
- Guess each material.
- Circle any strong reflections or highlights.

2. Trace the composition

- Place tracing paper over the image.
- Draw the main triangle or triangles, the horizon line, and the strongest diagonals.
- Note where Heda creates balance and where he creates near accidents.

3. Discuss in a small group

- How does Heda balance order and instability.
- Which two details feel most alive.
- Share one observation that connects form to meaning.

4. **Connect to ethics**

- You will receive a short quote from John Berger about value, possession, or seeing.
- Link the quote to two concrete details in the painting.

5. **Write your paragraph**

- 7 to 9 sentences.
- Make a clear claim about how Heda makes the circulation of goods visible.
- Use one formal detail and one trade or context fact.

Helpful vocabulary

Pronkstilleven, vanitas, trompe l'oeil, facture, specular highlight, repoussoir, motif, commodity, circulation, balance, diagonal

Quick tips

- Be specific. Name the object, name the material, describe what the light does.
- One strong claim is better than three weak ones.
- Use the vocabulary to be precise.

Likely objects you may spot

Gilt standing cup, pewter plate, half peeled lemon, Römer glass, white bread, knife with mother of pearl, napkin, overturned beaker, salt cellar